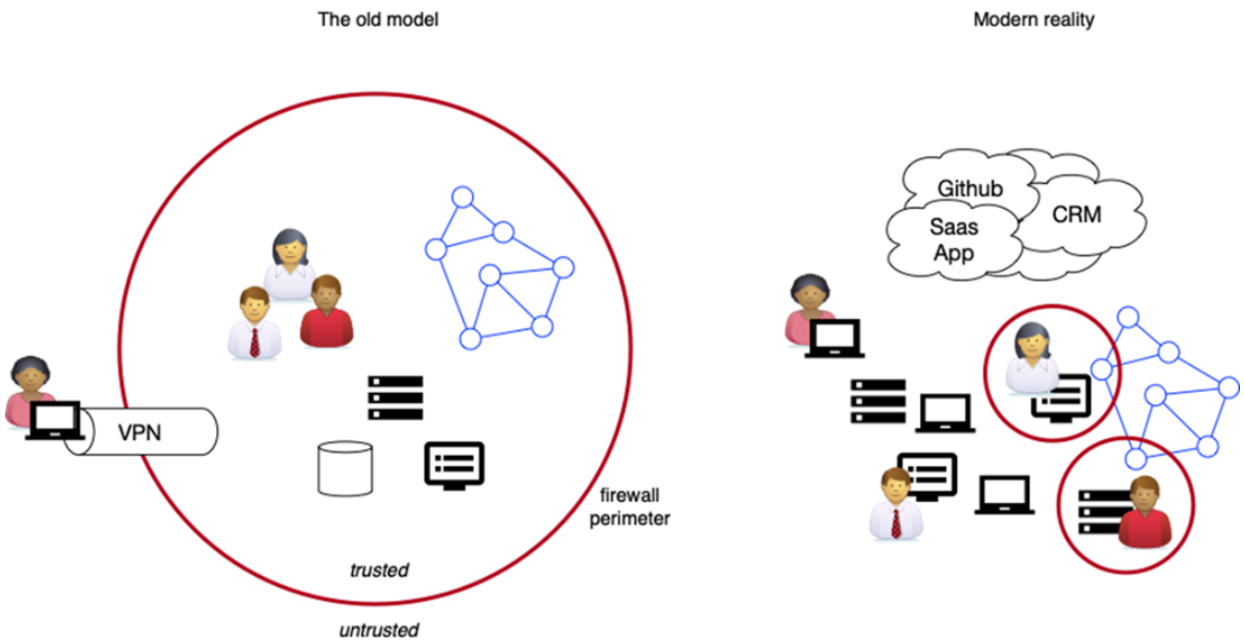


Figure 15.1 Why the perimeter model fails in modern environments. In the traditional model (left), a firewall defined a clear boundary, and anything inside the perimeter was implicitly trusted. In modern environments (right), cloud services, mobile work, SaaS applications, and external collaborators eliminate the concept of a meaningful boundary.

But ACME's world had changed. Employees worked from anywhere. Contractors connected to projects through other companies' networks. Critical systems resided in cloud environments, and entire business workflows relied on SaaS applications that sat far outside the old perimeter. Even ACME's Customer Collaboration platform linked thousands of customers directly to ACME-managed systems. The perimeter was no longer a protective wall; it was an architectural fiction.

And that fiction unraveled for three interconnected reasons. First, *location was no longer a reliable indicator of trust*; a request coming from the corporate network told Sam's team almost nothing about the person or device behind it. Second, *attackers increasingly exploited implicit trust once they gained access*, moving laterally across internal systems with surprising ease. Third, *users, devices, and workloads now operated from everywhere*, making it impossible to anchor security to a single boundary. In this environment, treating the network as a trust signal simply didn't hold.

Zero Trust developed as the industry's response to this shift, not as a product category, but as a security approach, a choice to replace inherited trust with